



**free will
and
determinism**

against
compatibilist
free will

against
incompatibilist
free will

More precisely, our topic is the relationship between freedom of the will and determinism, and a cluster of arguments which seem to show that free will is incompatible with both determinism and indeterminism, and hence impossible.

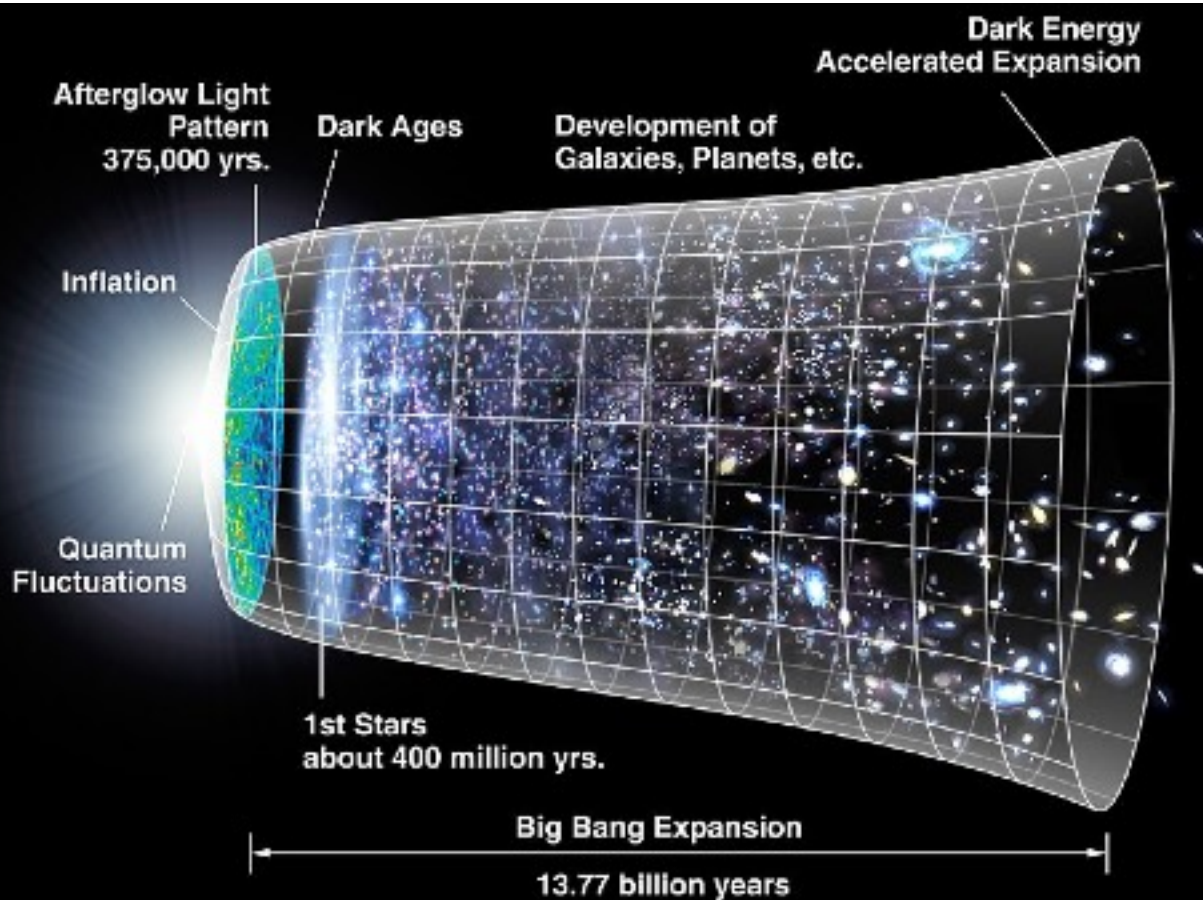
What is 'determinism'?

Consider a timeline of the history of the universe.

What determinism says is that, given a full specification of the state of the universe at one time, the laws of nature tell you exactly what will happen at every later time.

Our topic today is the challenge to free will posed by determinism.

"Determinism is the thesis that only one continuation of the state of things at a given moment is consistent with the laws of nature."



Sometimes people use 'determinism' as a name for the thesis that there is no free will, so that determinism rules out free will by definition. That is not how we are using the term. Determinism is a thesis about the laws of the nature. It is then an open question whether we could have free will in a world with deterministic laws.

Let's focus in on that question:

Is free will
compatible with
determinism?

The **incompatible** says 'No.' The **compatible** says 'Yes.'



This gives us three possible views about freedom of the will.

Freedom of the
will is real, and
compatible
with
determinism.

Freedom of the
will is real, and
incompatible
with
determinism.

There is no
free will.

1. Either (i) Compatibilism is true or (ii) Libertarianism is true or (iii) there is no free will.
2. Compatibilism is false.
3. Libertarianism is false.

C. There is no free will.

THE MASTER ARGUMENT AGAINST THE REALITY OF FREE WILL

It is important to see that this argument does not assume the truth of determinism. It just assumes that if free will is real, it must either be compatible with determinism or not. It then tries to rule out both possibilities.

Premise (1) says that one of the boxes must be true. Premise (2) says that it is not the left box, and premise (3) says that it is not the middle box.

The only remaining possibility is that there is no free will.

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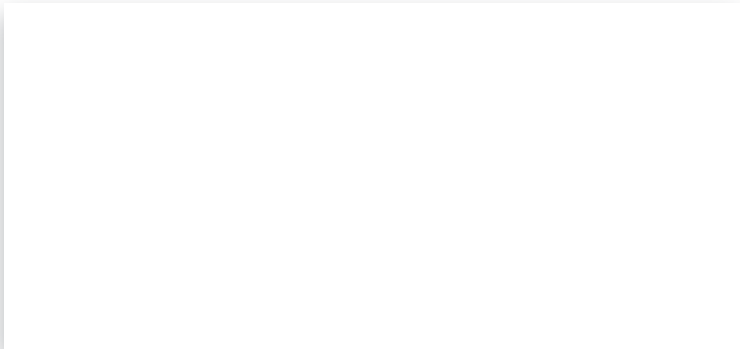
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compatible with

dear friends?









1. Either (i) $\text{Compat}i b i 1 i$ is true or (ii)

C. There is no fire in the will.



Libertarianism (iii) there is no free

2. compatibilists disagree.

W

i

1

1

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3:Libertarianism is false.



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varlatatie + the last of the

1. No one has any choice about events which

then DECISION happens. (3)

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

future is not as it was with the state of the

2. None has any choice about DIDS ATJR.

theorie about the fact that if DNR

then DECISION. (4,5)

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

of interest.

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

and none has any choice about whether,



happened in the distant past.

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

3. If determined, the only one

about whether @.



choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

combination of four - that No

choice principle, and determinism



rules out free will.

choice about the laws of nature, then no

one has any choice about the past, no

This argument seems to show that the

Since the first three of these theses

hence that free will is incompatible with

true, there are no free actions — and

seems to show that if determinism is

seem quite plausible, the argument







1. Freewill is incompatible with determinism.

2. If Libertarianism is true, there is no free

Wili.

0: There is no fire will.





Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).



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A red circular button with a slight drop shadow, containing the text "against incompatibilist free will" in white, lowercase, sans-serif font.

against
incompatibilist
free will

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

reality of free will.



1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.

2. If Libertarianism is true, there is no free



0. There is no fire in.

Wili.



believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

for (2), and one for (3).

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "against compatibilist free will" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

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